

Western Mountains



THE WESTERN MOUNTAIN RANGES, such as the Rockies, the Cascade Range, and the Sierra Nevada, provide a variety of habitats for birds, concentrated in a small space. The warm, wet weather on the lower mountain slopes encourages the growth of dense forests. These forests shelter and

feed many birds, from woodpeckers and nutcrackers to jays and chickadees. Higher up the mountains, it is cooler and drier, and the forests give way to grassy meadows and bare, rocky ground on the frozen peaks. Here, eagles and other birds of prey soar on rising air currents, which sweep over the mountains. A few unusual birds, such as ptarmigans, survive on the higher slopes—their downy feathers keeping them warm.

Black-billed magpie

The black-billed magpie is an adaptable bird that eats a range of foods, especially insects and small rodents. It often perches on the backs of cattle and sheep to pick off the ticks and maggots that live on their skin. It builds a large, strong nest of twigs, mud, and plant material, lined with fine grass and hair. A dome of sticks, often thorny ones, protects the top of the nest from predators.



Tail is longer than the body.

White-tailed ptarmigan

In winter, this ptarmigan grows white feathers, which camouflage it against the snowy landscape. It often crouches down in the snow to keep out of the fierce, cold mountain winds and to avoid predators. It tends to run away from danger instead of flying. In the summer breeding season, it grows mottled brown feathers. These are very useful to the female, as they hide her while she sits on her eggs.

White-tailed ptarmigan
(*Lagopus leucurus*)
Length: 1 ft 1 in (34 cm)

Feathers keep its feet warm.
Scales on the toes act as snowshoes to stop the bird sinking into snow.



Golden eagle
(*Aquila chrysaetos*)
Length: up to 3 ft (90 cm)
Wingspan: up to 7 ft 7 in (2 m 30 cm)

Strong talons for gripping prey, such as this rabbit, and flying with it.

Powerful, hooked bill for tearing flesh from prey.

Golden eagle

To hunt for food, the golden eagle soars high up in the sky on its powerful wings. When its sharp eyes spot a small mammal, it dives quickly down to seize its prey and crush it in its hooked talons. The golden eagle will attack animals as big as deer, especially in winter when other food is scarce. It builds enormous nests on rocky crags or in tall trees.

Black-billed magpie
(*Pica hudsonia*)
Length: 2 ft (60 cm)

Mountain chickadee

In spring and summer, the mountain chickadee nests in the mountain forests, but it moves down to warmer valleys in the cold winter months. There it joins flocks of other small birds, such as wood warblers and vireos, that roam the valley forests searching for food. If chickadees kept to their own territories in winter, they would not find enough food to eat.

Mountain chickadee
(*Poecile gambeli*)
Length: 6 in (15 cm)

The chickadee feeds on insects and seeds in conifers, such as this Douglas fir.

